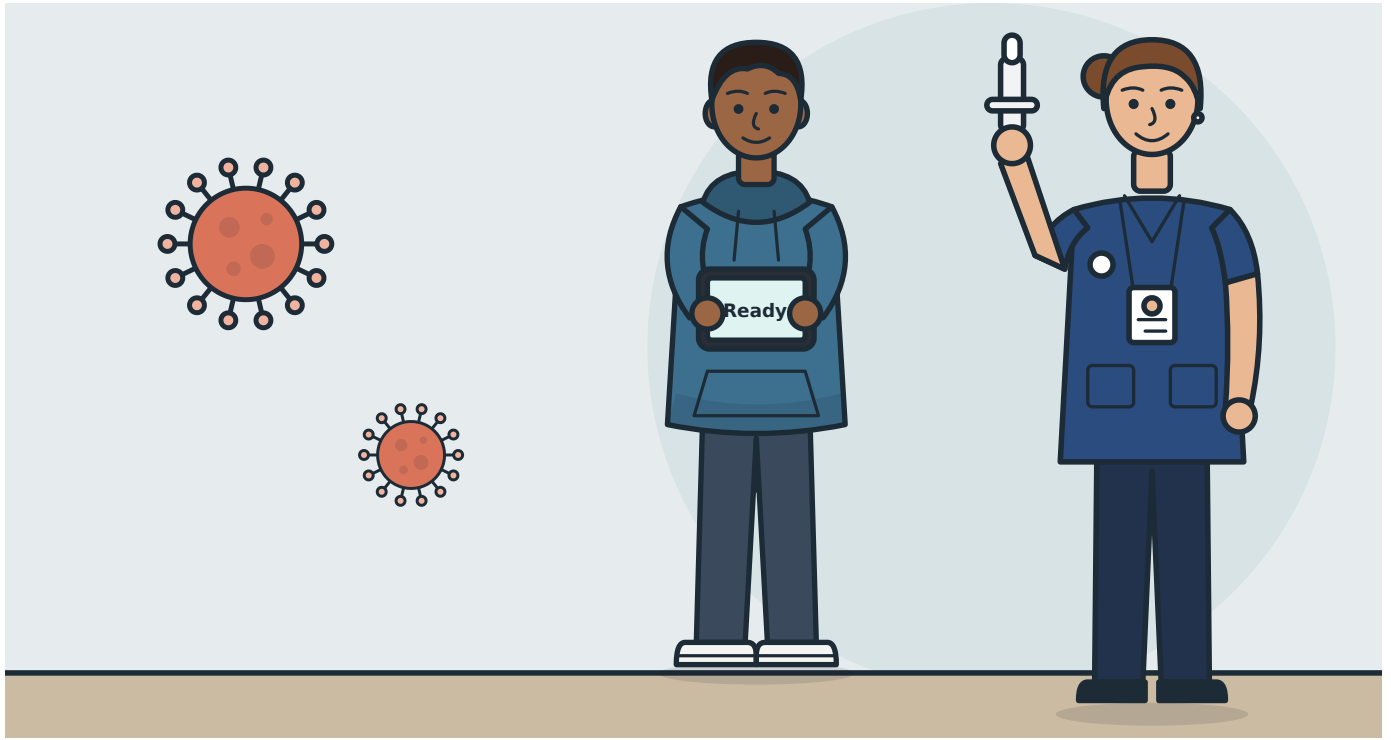




Sam and the Flu Spray

An autism-friendly guide to the nasal flu vaccine, for young people who understand a lot and sometimes find talking hard.

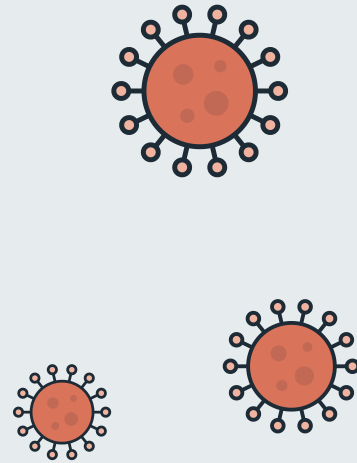
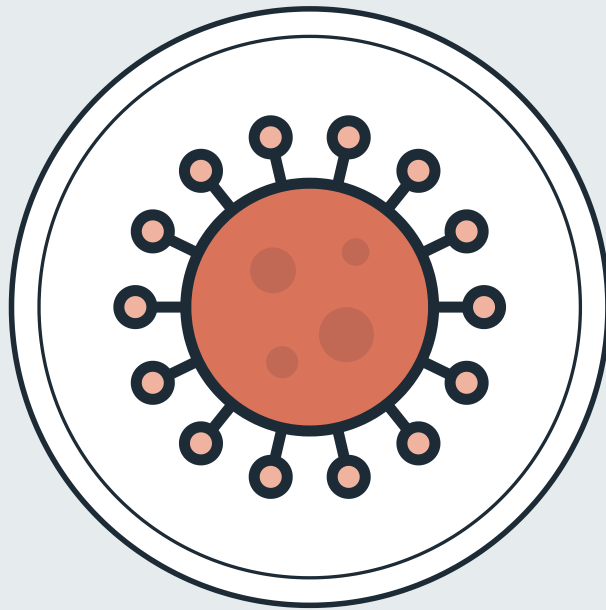


This is me

My name is Sam. I go to school every day.

I understand a lot. Talking can be hard for me, so I use my tablet and my cards to show people what I mean.

It can take me some time to answer. People can wait for me.



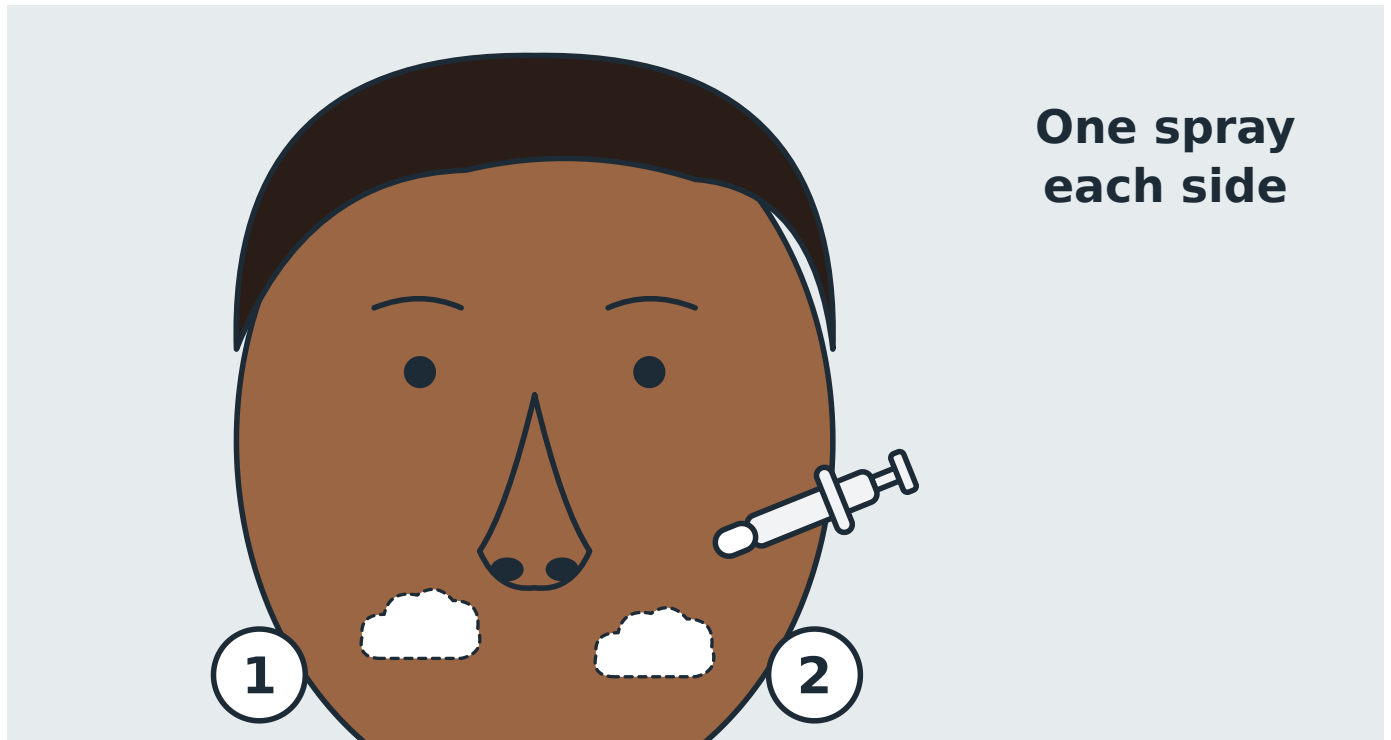
Flu virus, seen through a microscope

What is flu?

Flu is caused by a virus. A virus is far too small to see.

Flu can give you a high temperature, aches, a sore throat and make you very tired. Most people my age get better in about a week.

For some people, like my Nan and my baby cousin Ava, flu can be much more serious.



What is the flu spray?

Every year, schools offer a flu vaccine. For most young people it's a nasal spray.

That means a spray inside my nose. **One spray in each nostril.** It is not a needle. It usually takes less than 10 seconds.



Before the day

A letter comes home. My parent or carer fills in a form to say yes.

I can use my cards to tell staff how I'm feeling about it. It's OK to feel worried. Lots of people do.

Things that might be different

Sometimes plans change. This is OK.



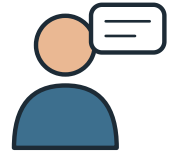
I might wait a short time or a long time.



The room might be different from last time.



A different nurse might do my spray.



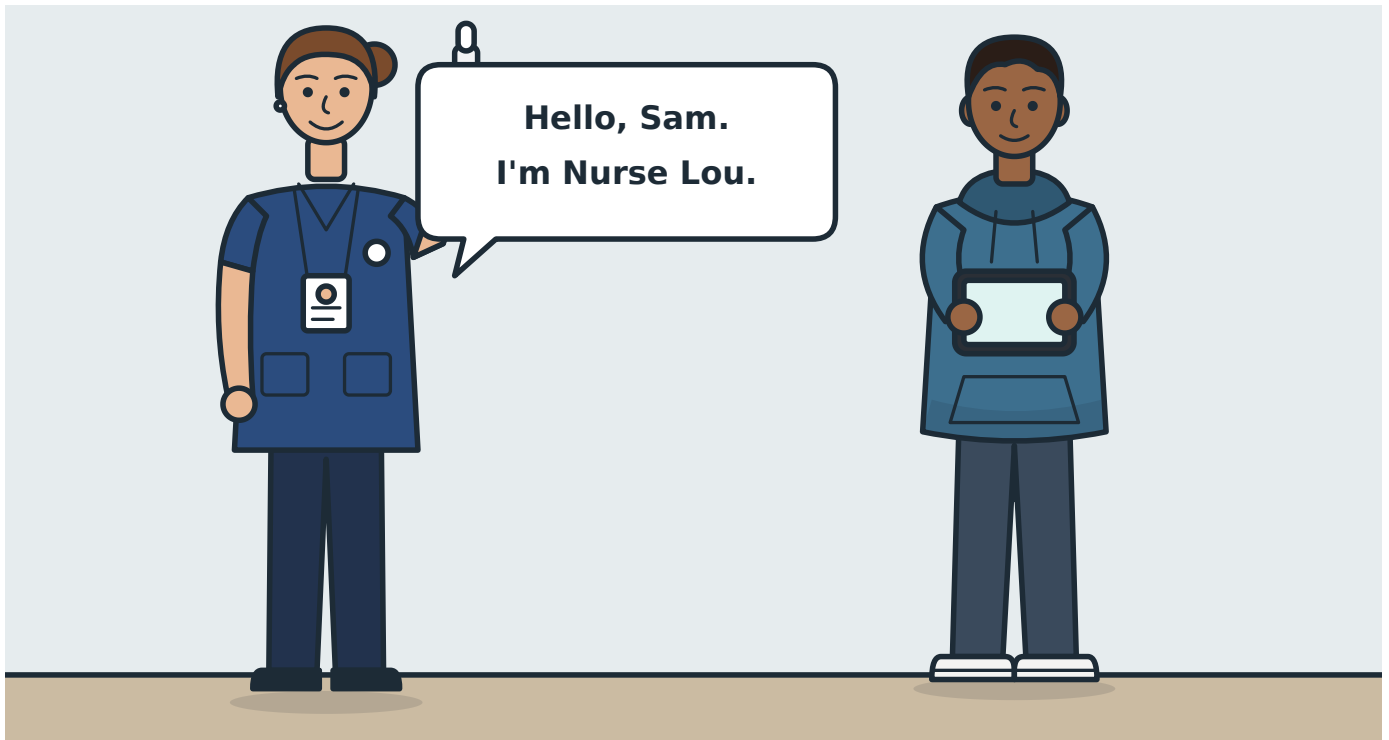
If something changes, a member of staff will tell me.



Waiting my turn

On the day, I wait my turn. I might wait with my class or with a member of staff I know.

I can bring something that helps me feel calm, like my headphones.

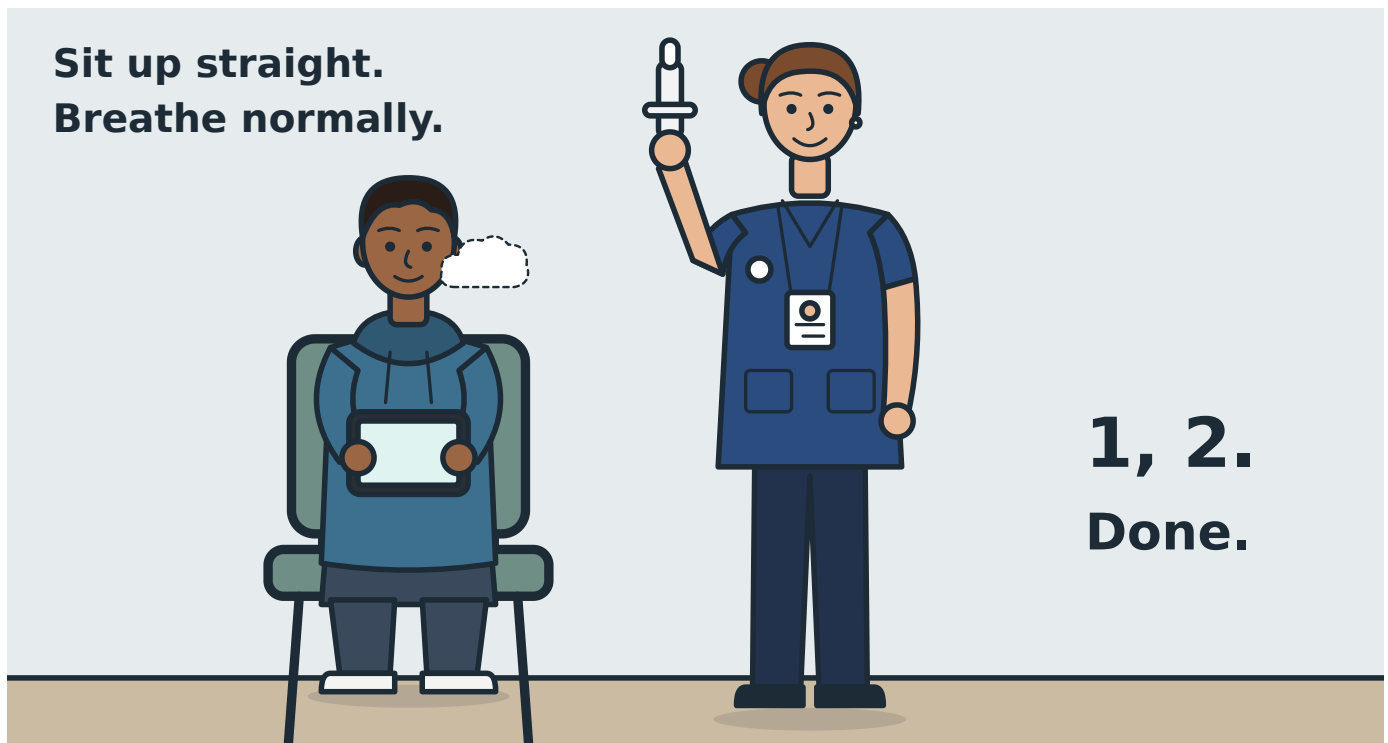


Meeting Nurse Lou

Nurse Lou works with the school immunisation team. She tells me what she's going to do before she does it.

I can show her my **Ready** card or my **Wait please** card.

Nurse Lou might make a joke to help me feel relaxed. I don't have to laugh or answer. I can just listen.



The spray

I sit up straight on the chair. I breathe normally. I don't need to sniff.

Nurse Lou says "Spray one" and sprays one side. Then she says "Spray two" and sprays the other side.

If I sneeze, that is OK. I do not need to have it again.

Then it is finished.

What I might notice

These are things I might see, hear and feel. Everyone is different.



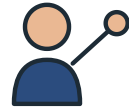
Sounds: people talking, chairs moving, doors opening.



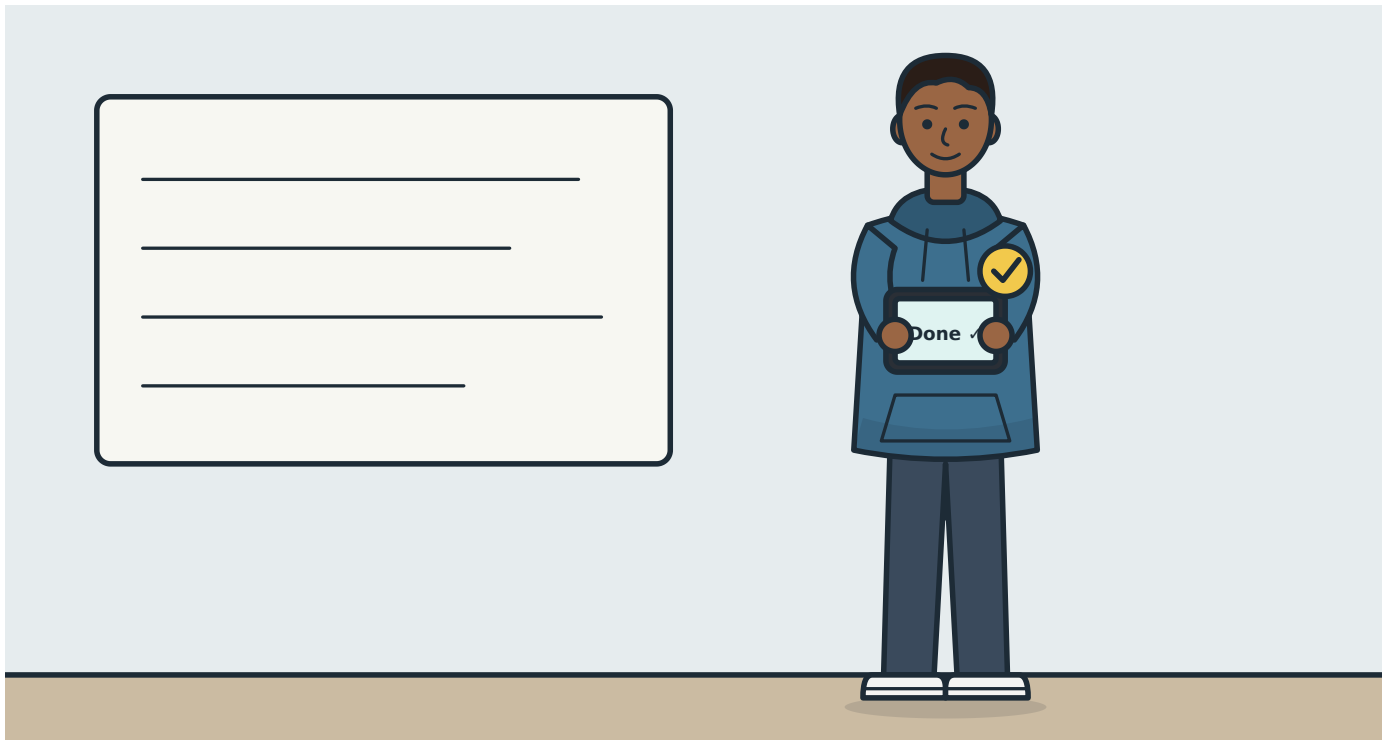
The room might be bright.



The spray might feel cold, wet or tickly inside my nose.



Nurse Lou will be close to my face for a few seconds. She will tell me first.



Afterwards

My nose might be runny or blocked for a day or two. I might feel a bit tired. This is normal. It usually stops after a day or two.

Then I go back to class.



Why it matters

Having the flu spray makes me less likely to catch flu. It also makes me less likely to pass it on.

That helps protect Nan, baby Ava and my friends.

Nan likes baking. She said she will bake a cake after my flu spray.

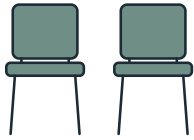
The flu spray takes a few seconds. It helps protect me and the people I care about.

It is OK to feel worried. I can use my cards, my tablet and the things that help me.

My flu spray schedule

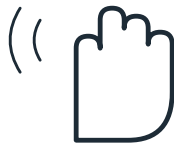
Go through it together before the day. Point to each step as it happens.

1



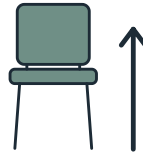
Wait my turn

2



Say hello to the nurse

3



Sit up straight

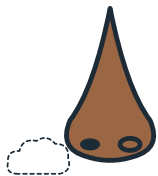
4



in and out

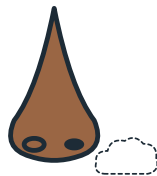
Breathe normally

5



Spray one side

6



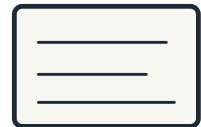
Spray the other side

7



All done

8



Back to class

Some young people have the flu vaccine as an injection instead. That's OK too. It protects in the same way.

Things that can help me

Tick the ones that help. Choose one or two to use on the day.



Headphones



Something to
hold or fiddle
with

1 2 3 4 5

Slow breaths
while I count to
5



A member of
staff I know



My break card



My tablet



Knowing how
long I will wait



Something
else: _____

First, then

Write or draw what happens after the spray.

First



Flu spray

Then



My communication cards

Print and cut out. Point to a card to tell staff what you need.

 Ready	 Wait please	 I need a break	 I'm worried
 Yes	 No	 All done	 Help

How I feel right now



1

Calm



2

OK



3

Unsure



4

Worried



5

Very worried

About me, for the nurse

Fill this in together and give it to the immunisation team on the day.

My name is

The best way to communicate with me is

Things that help me stay calm

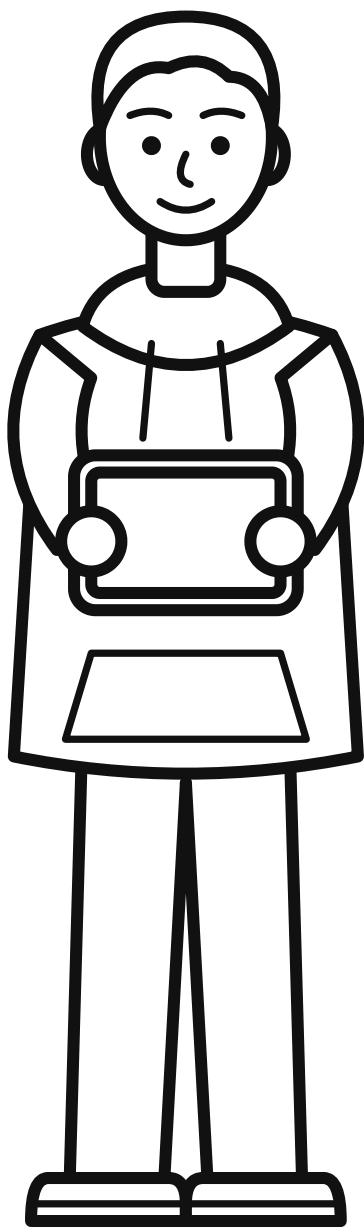
Please don't

After the spray, I'd like

Colouring pages

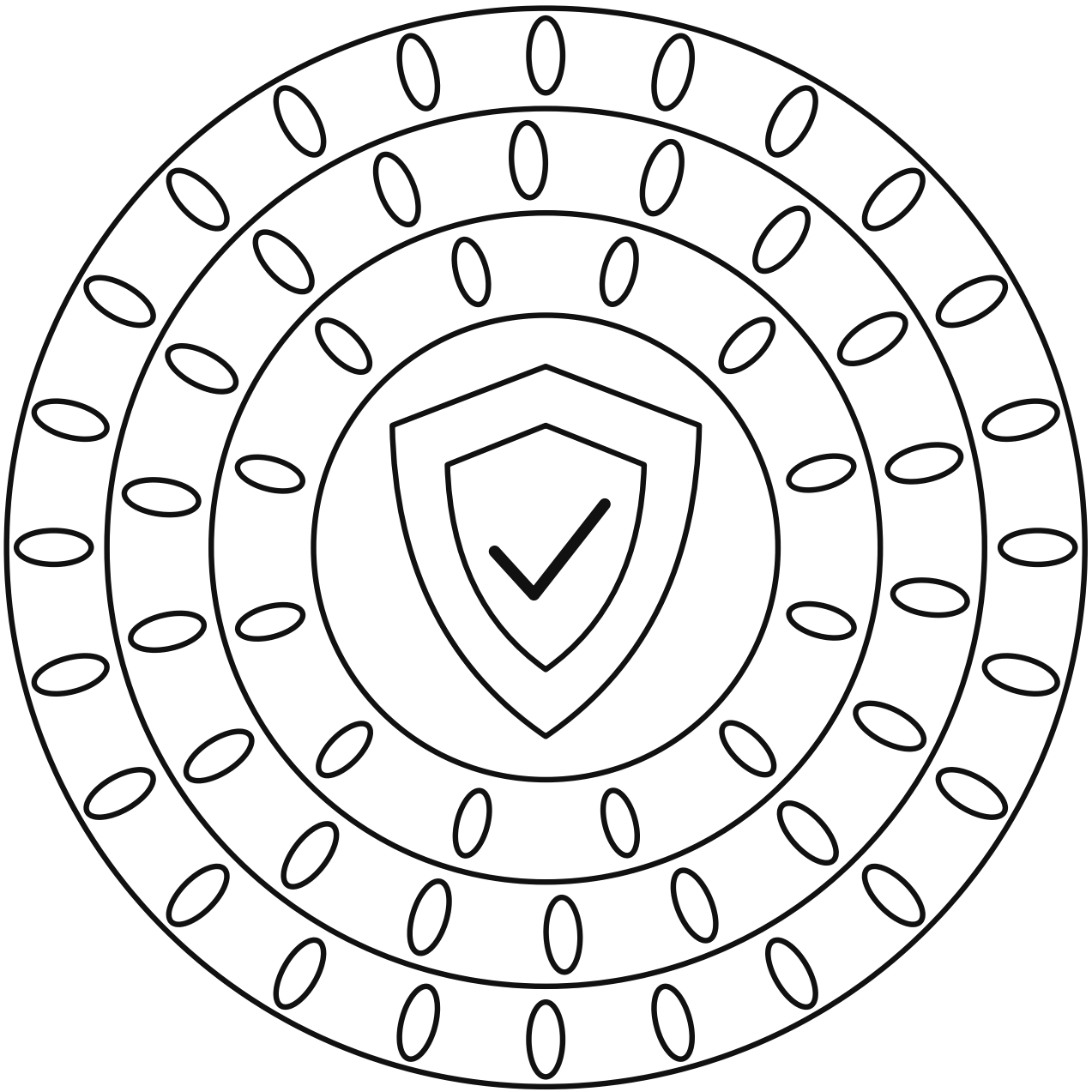
Four pages to colour. Take your time.

Sam

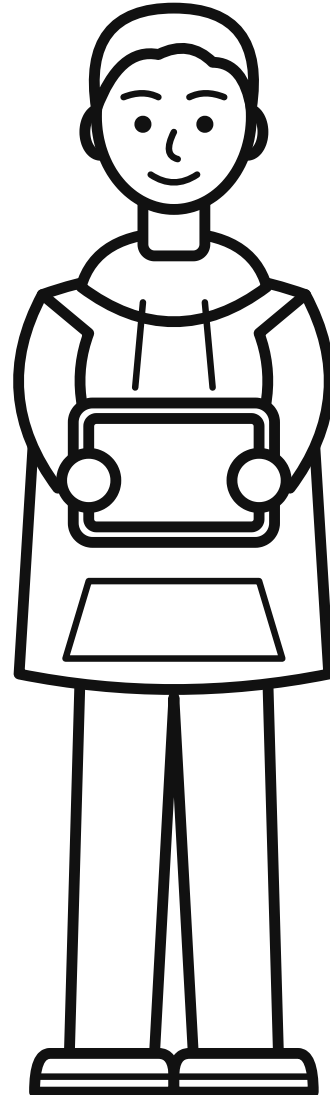
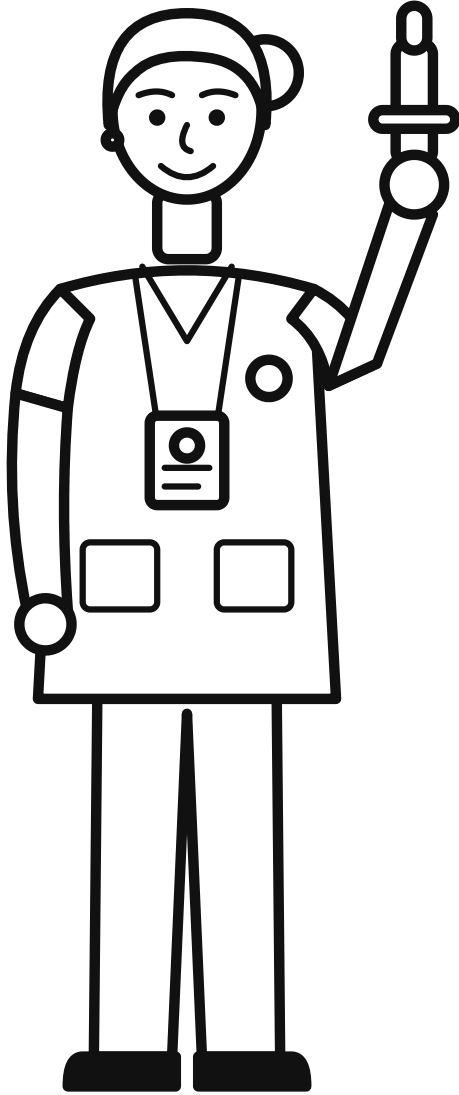




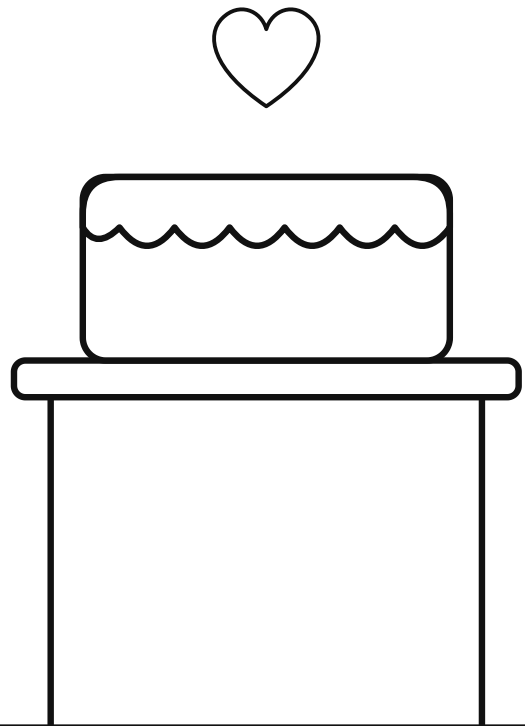
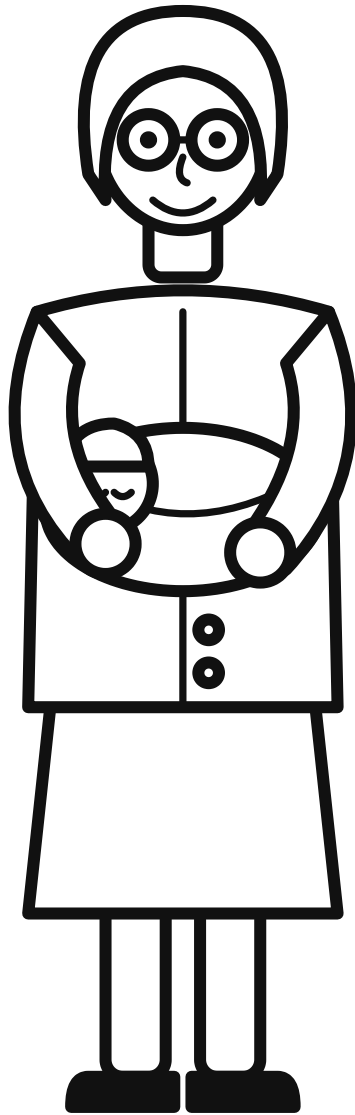
Protected



Nurse Lou and Sam



Nan and baby Ava



For parents, carers and staff

- The children's flu vaccine is usually a nasal spray: one spray into each nostril. It's quick and doesn't hurt. The young person doesn't need to sniff.
- Afterwards some young people get a runny or blocked nose, a headache, tiredness or a smaller appetite for a short time.
- Some are offered an injection instead, for example if the nasal spray isn't suitable for them.
- Vaccination lowers the chance of catching flu and helps stop it spreading to babies, older people and people with long-term conditions. It doesn't guarantee someone won't catch flu.
- Use literal language and say what will happen before it happens. Avoid "it won't hurt a bit" type phrases; say "it might feel cold or tickly".
- Tell the young person about changes as early as possible, such as a new time, room or nurse.
- Give processing time. Offer the communication cards and the feelings scale before, during and after. Accept a card as a full answer.
- Share the "About me" page with the immunisation team. Ask if a quieter space or a first or last slot is possible.
- Questions? Ask the school immunisation team, your GP practice or a pharmacist.